

Apium graveolens (Apiaceae)

Celery

More familiar as a vegetable than as a medicine, celery stems and seeds have long been taken for urinary, rheumatic, and arthritic problems. Celery is a good cleansing, diuretic herb, and the seeds are used specifically for arthritic complaints where there is an accumulation of waste products. The seeds also have a reputation as a carminative with a mild tranquilizing effect. The stems are less significant medicinally.



Celery is an important medicinal herb as well as a vegetable.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Britain and other European countries, celery is found growing wild along the English and Welsh coasts, and in marshlands. Widely grown as a vegetable, cultivated celery is less fragrant than the wild variety. It is propagated from seed in spring and harvested from midsummer to autumn.

Related Species

Celeriac (*A. graveolens* var. *rapaceum*) is a "turnip-rooted" variety of celery. A medicinal food, it has some of the same qualities as celery.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (1.5–3%) containing limonene (60–70%), phthalides, and beta-selinene
- Coumarins
- Furanocoumarins (bergapten)
- Flavonoids (apiin)

Key Actions

- Antirheumatic
- Carminative
- Antispasmodic

- Diuretic
- Lowers blood pressure
- Urinary antiseptic
- Anti-inflammatory

Research

- **Volatile oil** Research in the 1970s and 1980s showed that the volatile oil has a calming effect on the central nervous system.
- **Other research** A 1995 study in India found the seeds to have marked liver-protective activity. Extracts of the seeds may also lower blood fat levels. Iranian laboratory research from 2013 found that celery seed had a marked effect in lowering high blood pressure.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Ancient herb** Records show that celery has been cultivated for at least 3,000 years, notably in pharaonic Egypt, and it was known in China in the 5th century BCE. Throughout history, celery has been used as a food, and at various times both the whole plant and the seeds have been taken medicinally.
- **Cleansing properties** Today, the seeds are used for treating rheumatic conditions and gout. They help the kidneys dispose of urates and other waste products, and work to reduce acidity in the body as a whole. The seeds are useful in arthritis, helping to detoxify the body and improve the circulation of blood to the muscles and joints.
- **Diuretic** Celery seeds have a mildly diuretic and significantly antiseptic action. They are an



Celery

A biennial with a ridged shiny stem, glossy leaves, and small flowers, growing to about 20 in (50 cm).

Parts Used

Stems are eaten as a nourishing vegetable and made into juice.



Divided toothed leaves are aromatic

Chopped stem

Seeds contain volatile oil and are the main part used medicinally.

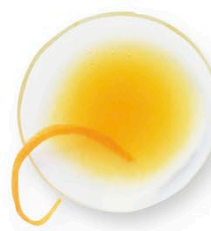


Seeds

Stem

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Do not take celery seed during pregnancy or if suffering from kidney disease. Do not use seeds sold for cultivation in medicinal preparations. Do not take the essential oil internally except under professional supervision.



Remedy As a cleansing drink, take $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of organic carrot and celery juice a day.



Tincture of seeds (to make, p. 292). For rheumatism, take 30 drops 3 times a day.



Infusion of seeds (to make, p. 291). For gout and arthritis, take $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) daily.



Powder of seeds. For arthritis, mix 1 tsp with food each day.

effective treatment for cystitis, helping to disinfect the bladder and urinary tubules.

■ **Nutritious drink** Celery and organic carrot juice make a nutritious, cleansing drink that is good for many chronic illnesses.

■ **Other uses** Celery seeds are

beneficial for chest problems such as asthma and bronchitis, and, in combination with other herbs, can help to reduce blood pressure.

Self-help Uses

- Arthritis, p. 313.
- Gout, p. 313.